in state. Doesn't go down well with allies



Files approved by Pawar will now be routed to CM Shinde via deputy CM Fadnavis for final approvals



BJP and Sena legislators reportedly upset at budgetary allocations Ajit made for his party MLAs



The NCP has staked claim to the guardian minister's post in Raigad, Satara, Pune and Nashik districts. Sena, BJP leaders are livid



The Maratha quota agitation (they are Kshatriyas who want to be put in the Kunbi [tillers] category) has Ajit's faction in a bind. The Kunbis and other OBCs vehemently oppose the move



The NCP is a 'Maratha-dominated' party, while the OBCs form part of the BJP's core base

also contributing to this. But an NCP leader close to Ajit insists that all is well. "The coordination between the three parties is good," he stressed, even though he admitted that it was not true of the middle-rung leaders and grassroots workers of the BJP and NCP, one reason being their diverse social base—the NCP is a predominantly Maratha party, while the BJP has support among the Other Backward Classes. BJP MLC Gopichand Padalkar, one of the leaders with a support base among the Dhangar (shepherd) community, has continued his vitriolic attacks against the Pawars.

A source within the Ajit camp also conceded that the leader was finding it difficult to move out of his uncle's shadow. "Traditionally, the Maratha voters are inclined towards the Congress. Even when Pawar Sr split in 1999 to form the NCP, he never drifted far from the larger Congress *parivar*. For most of the NCP's lifetime, it was in an alliance with the Congress. Ajit's challenge is to keep these Maratha voters, who have an emotional connect with Pawar Sr, with him," he says.

The source, however, pointed to how Ajit had managed to hold his own despite being a BJP ally, unlike Shinde whose identity and that of his party seemed to be subsumed by the BJP. CM Shinde is also a Maratha but he lacks Pawar's grip over the administration. This may help Pawar bolster his image as a doer and administrator and, by extension, become a probable CM candidate. "But here, he faces competition from Fadnavis. In addition, Fadnavis and the BJP have built a social coalition of the OBCs, which has helped loosen the vice-like grip the Marathas have over the state's political economy," the source explains.

Ajit's eventual fate will be determined by the performance of the grand alliance in the Lok Sabha election due next year. A good showing may even see him pole-vault into the CM's chair. A veteran journalist who has covered the NCP for a long time says, "The moot question is whether the BJP will prevail upon him to field his son Parth or wife Sunetra against cousin Supriya Sule from the Baramati Lok Sabha seat. If this happens, the larger Pawar clan will split down the middle and Pawar Sr may walk away with mass sympathy," he says.

AJIT'S FATE IS LINKED INEXORABLY TO HOW THE ALLIANCE PERFORMS IN THE 2024 LS POLL. A GOOD RESULT COULD MEAN PROMOTION TO CM

Ajit's tough image has also sullied by the shadow of the central investigation agencies. "The image of a leader also depends on his fight or flight impulse. Pawar Sr is seen as a fighter. Ajit's image, on the other hand, has taken a beating," he added. A senior Ajit faction leader denies this. "This is a lie. One reason for us joining hands with the BJP was that most of our legislators are first-timers and need to show some performance in their constituencies in terms of development works to get re-elected. Being in power will help...their future is at stake," he says.

Another NCP leader says that the differences were more pronounced between the BJP and Shinde's Sena. "The NCP's voters and those of these two parties are different.... But the BJP and the Sena compete for the same vote base," he explains. The BJP's decision to take the NCP along was not dictated by numbers in the assembly (where they have a comfortable majority), but to ensure a good showing in the Lok Sabha election. In 2019, the BJP and the undivided Shiv Sena won 41 of the 48 seats; a similar performance is crucial in Maharashtra for the Narendra Modi-led BJP to return to power for a third time in 2024.

Senior journalist Sandeep Pradhan says, "Taking in the NCP is perhaps BJP's acknowledgement that Shinde cannot deliver for the alliance in the Lok Sabha poll." He feels the alliance has not benefitted any of the members, pointing to the constant speculation on whether Shinde will be replaced as an example. As for the BJP, Pradhan sees it as the biggest loser in the triumvirate—it stands in third place despite having the highest numbers. The impact that this has had on the morale of the BJP cadre is its biggest drawback yet. ■